

HCIF

Horizon Community Impact Foundation

Community Impact Grant

Annual Request for Proposals

Letter of Inquiry deadline	August 15 annually
Full proposal deadline	September 30 annually, 11:59 p.m. Eastern Time
Award amount	\$50,000-\$100,000
Project period	12 months, beginning January 1 following the application deadline
Eligible applicants	U.S.-based nonprofit organizations and eligible nonprofit partnerships
Funding decision	Applicants notified by December 15

Educational simulation notice: HCIF is a fictional foundation created for COMM 355. This opportunity does not provide actual funding, and proposals must not be submitted to a real organization without authorization.

1. About the Foundation

The Horizon Community Impact Foundation (HCIF) invests in nonprofit initiatives that expand opportunity, strengthen community well-being, and produce meaningful, measurable benefits for people and communities across the United States. HCIF values community-informed solutions, responsible stewardship, collaboration, and practical approaches that can be sustained beyond the grant period.

2. Funding Opportunity

Through the Community Impact Grant, HCIF supports one-year projects that respond to a clearly documented community need. Competitive proposals will demonstrate a strong connection among the identified need, the proposed activities, the people who will benefit, and the outcomes the project is expected to achieve.

Applicants may request between \$50,000 and \$100,000. Matching funds are not required. HCIF may award less than the amount requested and may request clarification or budget adjustments before making a final award.

3. Funding Priorities

Each proposal must identify one primary funding priority. Projects may address more than one priority, but applicants should explain where the project has its strongest alignment.

- **Education:** Expand literacy, college access, after-school learning, and lifelong-learning opportunities.
- **Workforce Development:** Strengthen career preparation, technical skills, advancement, and access to employment.
- **Health and Wellness:** Improve health-care access, physical and mental health, food security, and healthy lifestyles.
- **Community Development:** Promote housing stability, civic engagement, community partnerships, public safety, and neighborhood strength.
- **Technology and Digital Access:** Expand broadband access, digital literacy, technology equity, and pathways to technology careers.
- **Environmental Sustainability:** Support conservation, environmental stewardship, community resilience, and green-workforce opportunities.

4. Eligibility

Eligible applicants

The lead applicant must meet one of the following conditions:

- A nonprofit organization recognized by the Internal Revenue Service as tax-exempt under Section 501(c)(3) and in good standing.
- A public agency applying in formal partnership with an eligible 501(c)(3) nonprofit organization.
- A community-based organization applying through an eligible 501(c)(3) fiscal sponsor that accepts fiduciary and grant-management responsibility.

The proposed project must primarily benefit a community or population within the United States. The applicant must demonstrate sufficient organizational capacity to manage the project, account for grant funds, and report results.

Ineligible applicants and activities

- Individuals, for-profit businesses, and organizations without eligible nonprofit status or fiscal sponsorship.
- Political campaigns, partisan activities, lobbying, or attempts to influence legislation.
- Religious instruction or activities requiring participation in religious practice as a condition of receiving services.

- Endowments, debt retirement, fundraising events, regranting, or costs incurred before the project period.
- Major construction, property acquisition, or equipment purchases that are not essential to the proposed project.
- Projects whose primary purpose is producing commercial media, publications, or promotional materials.

5. Allowable Costs

Grant funds may support reasonable and necessary project expenses, including:

- Project personnel and contracted expertise.
- Program materials, supplies, technology, and participant supports.
- Outreach, accessibility, transportation, and other costs necessary for participation.
- Data collection, evaluation, and dissemination of project results.
- Administrative or indirect costs not exceeding 10% of the amount requested.

All expenses must be clearly connected to the proposed activities and justified in the budget narrative.

6. Application Process

The Community Impact Grant uses a two-stage application process.

Stage 1: Letter of Inquiry

A Letter of Inquiry (LOI) is required and must be submitted by August 15. The LOI may not exceed two pages and should include:

- The applicant organization's name, mission, nonprofit status, and primary contact.
- A concise description of the community need and the population to be served.
- A summary of the proposed project, anticipated outcomes, and approximate amount requested.
- An explanation of alignment with HCIF's mission and one primary funding priority.
- A brief statement of organizational capacity and any significant partners.

HCIF reviews LOIs for basic eligibility, alignment, and readiness. Selected applicants will be invited to submit a full proposal. An invitation does not guarantee funding.

Stage 2: Full Proposal

Invited applicants must submit a complete proposal by September 30. The proposal narrative may not exceed seven pages, excluding the cover letter, executive summary, budget materials, project timeline, logic model, references, and required attachments.

- **Cover Letter:** A brief letter accompanying the proposal that identifies the applicant organization, project title, funding priority, amount requested, project period, and primary contact and explains the significance of the proposed project.

- **Executive Summary (Proposal Summary):** A concise overview of the community need, proposed response, population to be served, amount requested, and expected results. Maximum 300 words.
- **Problem Statement (Statement of Need):** A compelling, evidence-based description of the community need to be addressed, including the affected population, contributing conditions, service gaps, and why action is needed.
- **Organizational Background:** A description of the organization's mission, history, qualifications, relevant experience, population served, staff and partner roles, and capacity to administer the proposed project and grant funds.
- **Goals and Objectives:** A description of what the organization ultimately hopes to accomplish through the project and the specific, measurable results or outcomes expected during the grant period.
- **Strategies:** A description of the programs, services, activities, staffing, partnerships, and implementation approach that will be used to achieve the proposed goals and objectives.
- **Evaluation:** A plan for assessing project accomplishments, including indicators, data sources, collection methods, responsibilities, and how findings will be used to improve implementation.
- **Sustainability:** A description of how the organization will develop additional funding or otherwise continue the project's essential activities and benefits after the initial HCIF grant period.
- **Budget:** An itemized project budget showing how the requested funds and other resources will be used, accompanied by a narrative explaining and justifying the proposed expenses.
- **Required Attachments:** A project timeline, logic model, governing-board list, IRS determination letter or fiscal-sponsor documentation, and any other materials specified in the application instructions.

7. Formatting and Submission Requirements

- Use an accessible, professional typeface of at least 11 points and margins of at least one inch.
- Use clear headings corresponding to the application components listed in this RFP.
- Cite all external data and sources using a consistent professional citation style.
- Submit all required components through the HCIF application process by 11:59 p.m. Eastern Time on the applicable deadline.
- If a published deadline falls on a weekend or U.S. federal holiday, the deadline moves to the next business day.
- Late or substantially incomplete applications will not be reviewed.

8. Review Criteria

HCIF conducts an eligibility and completeness review before proposals advance to the grant-review committee. Eligible proposals are evaluated using the following criteria:

Criterion	What reviewers consider	Points
Mission and priority alignment	Clear fit with HCIF's mission, the selected funding priority, and the purpose of the Community Impact Grant.	15
Community need	Specific, credible evidence of need and a clear understanding of the people and conditions the project will address.	15
Project design and feasibility	Logical goals, activities, timeline, staffing, partnerships, and a feasible implementation approach.	20
Outcomes and evaluation	Meaningful, measurable results supported by appropriate indicators, data sources, and evaluation methods.	15
Organizational capacity	Relevant experience, responsible leadership, appropriate partnerships, and capacity to manage the project and award.	10
Budget and cost effectiveness	Reasonable, allowable, well-justified costs that align with project activities and anticipated results.	10
Sustainability and lasting value	A credible approach to sustaining benefits, effective practices, partnerships, or essential activities.	10
Clarity and responsiveness	Professional, persuasive, well-organized writing that follows the RFP and application requirements.	5

9. Review and Award Process

- HCIF staff screen submissions for eligibility, completeness, and compliance with the RFP.
- A review committee independently scores eligible proposals using the published criteria.
- The committee considers scores, portfolio balance, available funds, and potential community benefit when developing recommendations.
- HCIF may request clarification, conduct a brief applicant interview, or negotiate the scope and budget before making an award.
- All applicants receive written notification. Funding decisions are final.

10. Annual Funding Cycle

Milestone	Annual timing
Letter of Inquiry due	August 15
Invitation decisions	By September 1
Full proposal due	September 30
Review and clarification	October-November
Award notification	By December 15
Project period	January 1-December 31 following the application deadline
Selecting the applicable cycle: Applicants should use the next available September 30 deadline. In the COMM 355 simulation, spring and summer students ordinarily use the current year's cycle, while fall students ordinarily use the following year's cycle.	

11. Questions and Applicant Responsibility

Applicants are responsible for reviewing the complete RFP, determining organizational and project eligibility, and submitting all required information by the applicable deadline. HCIF responses to frequently asked questions and applicant guidance will be published on the foundation website. Guidance does not replace the requirements stated in this RFP.

Questions should be submitted through the HCIF website. To ensure fair access to information, HCIF does not provide individualized feedback on proposal competitiveness before submission.

12. Reservation of Rights

HCIF may amend or cancel this funding opportunity, request additional information, reject any or all applications, make no awards, or negotiate proposal scope and budget. Submission of an application does not create an entitlement to funding or reimbursement for proposal-development costs.

Course-use note: This draft is designed to support an authentic grant-writing simulation. Final website language, application templates, and COMM 355 assignment instructions should remain consistent with these requirements.